KINGKILLER CHRONICLE

TEXT ADVENTURE

Project Planning Document — v2.0

> *For MVP, this project is a Kvothe-only University vertical slice. All other eras, protagonists, and high-mystery content are deferred until the slice is complete, canon-audited, and tonally stable.*

Built on the published Kingkiller Chronicle by Patrick Rothfuss

The Name of the Wind (2007) · The Wise Man's Fear (2011) · The Slow Regard of Silent Things (2014)

SECTION 0 — PROJECT MODE AND RIGHTS

0. Project Mode and Rights

This section must be resolved before any build work begins. The release mode determines how the project is scoped, what text can be incorporated, and what legal exposure exists.

0.1 Choose Your Release Mode

Select exactly one of the following:

Mode	Definition and Constraints
A — Private prototype	Built for personal play only. Never shared publicly. Lowest risk. Can use direct text quotations internally for reference. No distribution. No review needed for IP purposes.
B — Private playtest	Shared with a small invited group (under 20 people). Non-commercial. No public distribution. Exercise caution with quoted canon text.
C — Public non-commercial demo	Publicly accessible but free, no monetisation, clearly labelled fan work with attribution. Requires careful handling of quoted text, character names, and world elements. Rothfuss has historically tolerated respectful fan works, but this is not a right. May require a fan-work declaration.
D — Public commercial release	Not permitted without a licensing agreement with Rothfuss/DAW Books. Do not build toward this without legal counsel and formal rights negotiation. This plan does not support Mode D.

0.2 Hard Gates by Mode

Mode A: No public posting, no revenue, no distribution. Full creative latitude internally.

Mode B: No public posting, no revenue, explicit invitation-only. Attribution to source works required.

Mode C: Clear fan-work labelling required on all public interfaces. No revenue. No false claims of official status. Avoid reproducing substantial passages of copyrighted text verbatim in the game's playable output. Character names and world elements are generally acceptable for transformative fan works under fair use principles, but legal risk is not zero.

> *HARD GATE: Decide your mode before writing a single line of content. Mode C adds constraints that affect the design of the narration system (no long verbatim text reproduction), the attribution layer, and the public presentation. If you haven't decided, default to Mode A and treat everything as private until you have.*

0.3 Recommended Position

Begin in Mode A. Develop the MVP fully. If and when you consider public release, reassess with Mode C requirements in mind from the start of Phase 3.

SECTION 1 — PROJECT VISION

1. Project Vision

1.1 What Kind of Game Is This?

This is a simulation-first, narrative-rich, canon-faithful interactive fiction experience. Not a combat system with story wrapping. Not a choose-your-own-adventure. Not a dungeon crawler with Rothfuss aesthetics applied as texture.

It is a game where inhabiting the world is the point. Where going to the Eolian and listening to a lute player for an evening is a complete and meaningful turn. Where running out of money has weight. Where a reputation damaged by one ill-chosen sentence at the wrong table follows the player for weeks.

The primary experience is: being someone specific, somewhere specific, at a specific moment in a living, socially textured world.

> *This project does not aim to simulate the entire Four Corners at once. It aims to create a dense, truthful slice of lived reality within canon. Depth outranks breadth. Repetition with variation outranks map size. Social plausibility outranks content volume.*

1.2 What Does 'Faithful to Rothfuss' Mean in Practice?

Four things operating simultaneously:

- **Tonal faithfulness.** The prose should feel intelligent, quiet, and precise. It earns its moments of beauty by surrounding them with grit and hunger and boredom and cold. It does not perform lyrical beauty constantly.
- **Structural faithfulness.** Rothfuss builds through accumulation of small true detail, not through dramatic peaks. The game must allow and reward that pace. Kvothe counting coins under a lamp before deciding whether to eat or save for tuition should feel as significant as a scene with Elodin.
- **Mystery faithfulness.** The books are fundamentally about what we do not know. The Chandrian, the Amyr, the Lackless family, the Doors of Stone — these are not puzzles to be solved by a clever player. They are the permanent horizon. Satisfying the player's curiosity cheaply would be a betrayal of what makes this world work.
- **Material faithfulness.** Money is specific in these books. Talents, jots, drabs. Tuitions are specific. The cost of a room at Anker's is specific. These details exist and must be honoured.

1.3 What Makes It Feel Unlike a Generic Fantasy Text RPG?

These five things, above all else:

1. Consequences are social, not just physical. You don't simply take damage — you lose standing, access, trust.
2. Magic is not a power system. Sympathy costs alar focus and body heat. Naming is rare and not reliably available. There is no mana bar.
3. The world does not revolve around the player. NPCs have lives. Events happen without the player. The University has politics the player only partially observes.
4. Slowness is rewarded. Paying attention to a rumour. Learning a song. Watching how someone moves through a room. These are valid and valuable actions.
5. Uncertainty is not a failure state. Not knowing something is the correct condition. The game models partial information, rumour, hearsay, and deliberate ambiguity as features, not bugs.

SECTION 2 — DESIGN PILLARS

2. Design Pillars

Pillar	Statement
1 — Canon First	Every design decision defers to published text. If something is not in the books, it does not get invented and presented as fact.
2 — Mystery Preserved	The great unresolved questions of the series must never be answered by the game. They must feel heavier and more present the deeper the player goes, not lighter.
3 — Social and Material Realism	Class, gender, rank, money, hunger, shelter, debt, favours, and reputation all function as real variables. The world is not fair, and the game does not pretend it is.
4 — Location Density and Geographic Coherence	Every named location must feel like it has rooms, thresholds, smells, sounds, and regular inhabitants. Movement between places takes real time with real costs.
5 — Character Authenticity	Every canon character must speak, think, and behave like themselves. They cannot be flattened into quest-givers or plot tools.
6 — Magic as Discipline, Not Power Fantasy	Sympathy requires training, focus, materials, and carries physical cost. Naming is rarer, less reliable, and more dangerous still. No spell lists. No cooldowns.
7 — Timeline Precision	Each era is distinct. NPCs who are dead in one era are alive in another. No meta-knowledge bleeds across eras.
8 — Consequences That Accumulate	Actions have effects that persist. A lie told to a master in Week 3 affects how that master treats the player in Week 8.
9 — Slow Play Rewarded	Observation, listening, patience, and restraint should be mechanically and narratively meaningful. The game resists the impulse to always push the player toward action.
10 — Prose That Is Original and Tonally True	The narration must not copy Rothfuss. It must feel compatible with him. Clear, careful, slightly lyrical, never breathless. Rooted in material detail.
11 — Engine Owns Truth	The structured game engine, not the LLM, owns state, legality, travel, economy, and canon flags. The LLM narrates. It does not decide facts.
12 — Small Enough to Finish	Every phase must produce a playable artefact, not just more planning. Scope is actively defended at every stage.

SECTION 3 — SCOPE DEFINITION

3. Scope Definition

3.1 Must Have (MVP — No Game Without These)

- One fully realised era: early University, Kvothe only
- 8–12 locations in a coherent campus and Imre cluster
- 3 fully realised NPCs, 2 semi-realised NPCs
- Sympathy magic modelled with cost, skill, and consequence
- Academic rank and tuition pressure
- Money and basic material needs (lodging, food, tuition)
- Reputation system with separate axes
- Conversation that rewards careful attention
- Persistent world state tracking choices and consequences
- Preserved mystery — unresolved lore stays unresolved
- Tone-correct narration passing book-reader review
- One canon-fixed event handled correctly

3.2 Should Have (Important — Game Is Weaker Without These)

- Music and performance system at Anker's and the Eolian
- NPC schedules by daypart
- Weather and season affecting narration and travel
- Injury and health tracking
- Clue and rumour tracking for mysteries
- Imre fully navigable with Eolian stage mechanics
- Denna as a properly handled occasional NPC

3.3 Post-MVP — Deferred to Later Phases

- Multiple eras
- Multiple playable characters
- The Underthing
- Auri gameplay beyond a single carefully gated encounter
- Tarbean era
- Troupe childhood era
- Bast and Kote frame-story play
- Chandrian as playable characters

- Travel beyond University and Imre

3.4 Deferred Unless Proven Safe (Structurally Dangerous to Canon Fidelity)

> *The following ideas are not simply 'later' — they carry specific risks to canon fidelity or scope stability. Each requires its own dedicated design review before implementation.*

- Play as Chandrian — too much unresolved lore; risk of inventing and presenting as fact
- Felurian content — extremely easy to flatten into a trope; canon is partial
- Auri-first gameplay — requires the deepest canonical discipline; not ready until Underthing is fully modelled
- Frame-story-only mode — three characters, one location; only compelling after stateful play is proven
- Ademre cultural simulation — canon gives broad strokes; easy to invent badly

3.5 Should Not Have (Keep These Out Permanently)

- Combat as a central mechanic or focus
- A spell list or ability tree for magic
- Quest markers, objective tracking, UI gamey language
- Invented lore presented as canon fact
- Resolution of series mysteries
- Modern idiom, tone, or humour
- Procedural generation of locations or NPCs
- Fan theory content
- Unnamed generic NPCs as primary social content
- XP, levels, stats displayed as numbers to the player
- Content from any source other than the three published books

SECTION 4 — CANON AND LORE STRATEGY

4. Canon and Lore Strategy

4.1 Sources of Truth (Priority Order)

6. The Name of the Wind (2007) — primary
7. The Wise Man's Fear (2011) — primary
8. The Slow Regard of Silent Things (2014) — primary for Auri and the Underthing
9. Confirmed Rothfuss interviews and statements — secondary, with caution; subject to revision
10. Nothing else.

Fan wikis may be used as finding aids to locate relevant passages, but must always be verified against the actual text before any game element is built from them. Treat wikis as potentially contaminated with fanon.

4.2 The Three-Tier Confidence System

Tier	Definition and Use
Tier 1 — Direct canon	The book states it, unambiguously. ('The tuition was three talents and one jot.') Use freely. Always cite chapter.
Tier 2 — Strong implication	The text strongly implies something without stating it explicitly. Use with caution. Narrate as implied, not confirmed.
Tier 3 — Reasonable inference	A gap is filled by logic consistent with canon. Always flag. Never present as fact in the game world. Prefer leaving the gap.
Unknown / unresolved	Falls outside these tiers. Remains unknown in-game. The game honours 'we do not know' as a valid state.

4.3 The Canon Red List

The following propositions may never be asserted as settled fact anywhere in the game, in any form, at any point:

> *Canon Red List — Never Resolve In-Game*

- Denna's patron identity
- Final Amyr truth and present membership
- Full Chandrian motivations, backstory, and identities beyond what text confirms
- Any hidden Name not directly supported by text
- Unpublished Book 3 outcomes, events, or revelations

- What Kvothe 'truly' did to earn the name Kingkiller
- The exact nature and location of the Doors of Stone
- Whether Kvothe is alive or dead at the frame-story present

4.4 The Contradiction Register

Whenever two passages, versions, or implications are in tension, log the contradiction rather than smoothing it over. The contradiction register is a living document maintained alongside the Lore Register. Format:

Field	Content
Contradiction ID	Unique identifier
Claim A	First claim with source citation
Claim B	Second claim with source citation
Nature	Direct conflict / ambiguity / possible misread / edition difference
Resolution	How the game handles it — usually: present both as uncertain, or stay silent

4.5 The Provenance Rule

Every content asset — location description, NPC dialogue rule, item description, event definition, magic mechanic — must include provenance metadata before shipping:

- Source book
- Chapter or page reference
- Quote fragment or descriptive note from the text
- Confidence tier (1, 2, or 3)
- Reviewer status (unreviewed / reviewed / approved)

This turns 'canon-first' from a hope into an enforceable workflow. Any asset without provenance metadata is flagged as unshippable until it is added.

4.6 The Lore Register

The Lore Register is a living document with the following categories. All game content is checked against it before shipping.

Category	Key Fields
Locations	Name, tier, description from text, eras, relationships, canon source
Characters	Name, eras, status, speech style, capabilities, limitations, what is public/private/unknown, canon source
Institutions	Name, function, hierarchy, access rules, relevant eras

Currency & Economy	Names, values, confirmed prices where canon gives them
Magic Systems	Name, known rules, costs, limitations, tier
Customs & Sayings	Text, context, source
Timeline Events	Event, era, what it changes, canon source
Relationships	Character A, Character B, nature, what is known/implied/unknown
Mysteries	Question, what canon confirms, what is implied, what is unresolved — NEVER resolved in the game

4.7 Preventing Fanon Contamination

- All facts traced to specific text before use
- Wikis used as finding aids only — never as primary source
- Canon audit pass at the end of every content phase
- Common fanon exclusion list maintained and reviewed at audit

Common fanon to actively exclude: specific Chandrian identities as settled fact, specific patron identity as settled fact, any resolution of mysteries Rothfuss has not resolved, content from any unpublished source.

4.8 Handling Unknown or Unresolved Lore

Two approaches, in order of preference:

11. **In-world uncertainty.** Characters in the game have incomplete, contradictory, or mythologised information, just as they do in the books. The in-world characters also do not know. This is the preferred approach — it honours how the books actually handle these gaps.
12. **Graceful silence.** The game simply does not go there. A door stays closed. A character deflects. An NPC gives three conflicting rumours. The narrator describes only what can be seen.

The game never presents 'unknown' as a wall. It presents it through the texture of the world itself.

SECTION 5 — WORLD MODEL

5. World Model

5.1 Structural Hierarchy

```
World
  └── Regions
        └── Settlements / Areas
              └── Location Clusters
                    └── Buildings / Spaces
                          └── Rooms
                                └── Objects / Details
```

The cluster is the real production unit — not the individual room. Build the entire Anker's cluster, the entire Fishery cluster, the entire Archive cluster. Clusters have internal coherence and external relationships.

5.2 MVP Location List (University Vertical Slice)

Exactly 11 locations across two clusters for the MVP. This is a hard ceiling, not a floor.

University Cluster

Location	Canon Basis and Notes
Kvothe's room (Mews or Rookery)	Repeatedly described in text; changes across terms as finances fluctuate
Anker's common room	Kvothe works here; detailed in text; social hub for students
Anker's side corridor / stairs	Implied geography; low invention risk; links room to common room
University main approach / courtyard	Referenced repeatedly; needed for arrival and transition
Mains exterior / entrance hall	Classes held here; confirmed location
Archives entrance / Tomes-access area	Detailed in text; access rules central to early University plot
Fishery outer workspace	Kilvin's domain; detailed in text; materials, tools, students
One master's admissions or office space	Admissions interview scene; Tier 2 for specific layout

Imre Cluster

Location	Canon Basis and Notes
Bridge between University and Imre	Confirmed geography; crossing takes real time
Imre street / approach	Referenced in text; not over-specified; keep general
Eolian floor / common area	Detailed in text; tiered seating, stage, atmosphere
Eolian stage threshold	The performance moment; access requires earned rights in-world

5.3 Location Fields (Full Schema)

Field	Purpose
id	Unique identifier
name	Display name
cluster_id	Which cluster this belongs to
era_availability	List of eras where this location exists and is accessible
description_base	Core description, tone-reviewed
description_variants	Object: {time_of_day, weather, player_state, world_state_flags, visit_count}
hours_open	When accessible (by daypart or specific hours)
traversal_cost	Time and fatigue to reach from each adjacent location
exits	Array: {direction, target_id, access_condition}
ambient_tags	Sound profile, smell profile, crowd level by daypart
social_hazard_flags	What risks exist here (observed, witnessed, overheard)
npcs_present	Array: {npc_id, conditions, schedule}
objects_present	Array: {object_id, conditions}
scene_templates	Pre-built scene fragments for first visit vs repeat visits
repeat_visit_counter	How many times the player has been here this session
canon_source	Book, chapter/page reference
tier	Confidence tier (1, 2, or 3)
off_limits_visible	Things the player can see but not reach

5.4 Location Availability by Era

Location	Troupe Era	Tarbean Era	University Era	Frame Era
Waystone Inn / Newarre	No	No	No	Yes
University (full campus)	No	No	Yes	Unknown — do not assert
Imre / Eolian	No	No	Yes	Unknown — do not assert
Tarbean	Briefly	Yes	Occasionally	Unknown
Troupe wagons and roads	Yes	No	No	No
Underthing	No	No	Yes — gated	Unknown
Vintas / Maer's Court	No	No	Late WMF only	Unknown
Ademre	No	No	Late WMF only	Unknown

> *The University in the frame era is listed as 'unknown — do not assert' because the text does not confirm its current state. Do not use 'ruins' or any other definitive description without a text citation.*

5.5 Travel and Physical Coherence Rules

- Travel between University and Imre: confirmed as a reasonable walk; exact time unstated but not instantaneous; treat as 20–30 minutes in-game time
- Travel to Tarbean: multiple days; requires transport, money, reason
- All travel: weather, time, fatigue, and cost are real variables
- Locked locations stay locked unless canonical events open them
- The Underthing: accessible only through specific entry points; Auri's routes are her own
- The Archives: restricted stacks require rank; the Four-Plate Door remains closed

SECTION 6 — CHARACTER MODEL

6. Character Model

6.1 Character Document Template

Every playable and major NPC character requires a complete character document before any dialogue or scene writing begins. The document must include:

Field	Content
Identity	Full name, aliases, physical description from text
Era availability	Which time periods, in what role
Speech style	Vocabulary, sentence rhythm, what they say vs what they withhold — drawn from canonical dialogue
Core temperament	Primary drives, fears, blind spots, what makes them move
Social position	Class, rank, institutional role, how others perceive them
Daily routine	Schedule by daypart — where they are when
Known capabilities	Confirmed by canon, with citation
Known limitations	What they cannot or will not do, with citation
Key relationships	With other canon characters, nature and limits
Taboo topics	What they refuse to discuss, deflect, or react badly to
What they are trying to hide	From canon implication — not invention
Conversation stance by relationship level	How they speak to a stranger vs a trusted acquaintance
What makes them end a conversation	Specific triggers
Kinds of lies they tell	In-character deception style
What they notice first about the player	Their observational priority
What causes tone shift	What changes their register
What is publicly known	What most people would know about them
What is privately known	What only some people know
What is unknown in canon	Must stay uncertain and must not be invented
Authority over player	Whether they can compel, restrict, punish, reward

6.2 MVP NPC Roster

Fully Modelled — Required for MVP

Character	Why Fully Modelled
Simmon (Sim)	Primary social anchor; warm, decent, perceptive; most daily University interaction passes through him; wrong voice would immediately break tone
Wilem (Wil)	Second primary social anchor; reserved, loyal, sceptical; contrasts with Sim; essential for social triangulation
Kilvin	Primary Fishery NPC; specific speech patterns from text (broken Commonwealth, characteristic expressions); controls access to Fishery work and income

Semi-Modelled — Sufficient for MVP

Character	Why Semi-Modelled
Anker	Functional daily interaction; less character depth needed; primarily environmental
Ambrose OR Denna (not both deeply)	Ambrose provides social antagonism; Denna provides emotional and narrative tension. Attempt one for MVP, not both at full depth.

6.3 Bespoke Rule Packs

The following four characters are too distinct for generic NPC handling. Each requires a bespoke rule pack — a separate document of specific constraints beyond the standard template.

Denna — Bespoke Rules

- She is never reliably available or consistently decipherable.
- She is not a romance reward. She is not a mystery box to be solved.
- She is intelligent, self-determining, economically precarious, and charming as a survival skill.
- Her patron's identity is in the Canon Red List. It must never be implied, gestured at, or narrowed.
- She must be able to leave a scene without explanation.
- She never becomes a companion or reliable ally.
- Her full name is not known at the start; do not give it before canon does.

Elodin — Bespoke Rules

- He is not a quirky wizard NPC. His strangeness has a logic the books gesture at without explaining.

- He must always leave more questions than answers.
- He never directly explains naming, the nature of his madness, or why he does what he does.
- He can end conversations without warning or apparent reason.
- He notices things the player would not expect him to notice.
- His authority is real and unpredictable. Do not make him safe.

Auri — Bespoke Rules

Auri is out of scope for the MVP except as a single carefully gated optional encounter. When she is eventually built, her document must be built entirely from The Slow Regard of Silent Things, not from The Name of the Wind alone.

- She must never be made to explain herself in conventional terms.
- Her world has rules — they are simply different rules.
- She must not become eccentric for flavour.
- Every interaction must be reviewed against SRST before shipping.

Ambrose — Bespoke Rules

- He is a genuine social threat, not a cartoon villain.
- He is socially skilled, well-connected, and operates through legitimate University channels.
- His hostility to Kvothe has reasons that are, from his perspective, defensible.
- He does not monologue. He manoeuvres.

6.4 Critical Character Notes — Kvothe as Player Character

- Brilliant and aware of it — but not omniscient.
- Impulsive in ways that cost him. Pride gets him into trouble.
- Genuinely poor for much of the University era; money pressure is real.
- Emotionally damaged about his parents; this surfaces in specific triggers.
- His skills are musical, academic, and sympathy — not superheroic.
- He does not have reliable access to naming. It is not a player ability.
- His Ruh identity is complicated — pride and vulnerability in equal measure.

SECTION 7 — TIMELINE MODEL

7. Timeline Model

7.1 The Five Canon Eras

Era	Description and Key Facts
Era 1 — The Troupe	Kvothe roughly age 8–12. Arliden and Laurian alive. Abenthy present briefly. Roads, wagons, performance, early sympathy lessons. Tonally warmest era — which makes its destruction matter.
Era 2 — Tarbean	Kvothe roughly age 11–15. Feral survival. Deep poverty. Skarpi. The Tehlin church. The city from underneath. Dark, slow, survivalist.
Era 3 — University	Admitted at roughly 15, unusually young. Richest era for gameplay. Two published books cover this period. Admissions through El'the advancement. The primary era for this project.
Era 4 — Beyond the University	Vintas, Ademre, Felurian's realm, the Maer's court. Less thoroughly detailed than University. High canon discipline required. Post-MVP.
Era 5 — The Frame	Kote at the Waystone Inn. Three days. Bast. Chronicler. The world is wrong. War nearby. Silence and dread. Post-MVP.

7.2 University Era Internal Timeline

The University era spans both published books with considerable detail. The MVP focuses on the very beginning — first term, first weeks. Key internal checkpoints:

- Admissions examination and interview with masters — canon-fixed
- Placement as E'lir — canon-fixed
- First tuition payment — canon-fixed financial pressure
- Meeting Simmon and Wilem — canon-anchored, player can influence texture
- First Fishery access through Kilvin — canon-anchored
- Archives access and Ambrose conflict beginning — canon-anchored
- First Eolian performance — canon-anchored, player can influence approach

Between these anchors, large stretches of daily life have no fixed canon detail — this is where player-driven play lives.

7.3 Knowledge State Per Era

Each era tracks not just what is true, but what the player character can know:

Knowledge Layer	Definition

What is objectively true in this era	Canon-confirmed facts and states of the world
What the player character would know	Based on what Kvothe has experienced so far
What the public believes	Common knowledge, rumour, folk mythology
What specific NPCs know	Their individual information states
What is only rumoured	Unconfirmed and possibly wrong
What is mythologised	Stories that have grown beyond their origins

> *Cross-era knowledge contamination is a critical failure mode. A player must never have access to information their character would not have at that exact moment in canon time. Player state resets cleanly when switching eras.*

SECTION 8 — CORE GAMEPLAY SYSTEMS

8. Core Gameplay Systems

8.1 Time Model

The time unit must be defined explicitly before any schedule or consequence system can be built. Recommended unit: scene-based turns with daypart tracking.

Daypart	Approximate Hours and World State
Early morning	Pre-dawn to 7am. Campus quiet. Archives not yet open. Anker's closed.
Morning	7am to noon. Classes active. Fishery open. Mains busy.
Afternoon	Noon to 5pm. Study, Fishery, Archives open. Imre accessible.
Evening	5pm to 9pm. Anker's busy. Eolian operating. Classes closed.
Night	9pm to midnight. Reduced access. Anker's winding down. Underthing accessible.
Late night	Midnight to pre-dawn. Restricted. Dangerous for some routes. Auri sometimes present.

A scene-based turn is approximately 30–60 minutes of in-world time. Moving between clusters costs one daypart segment. Actions within a location cost minutes to a scene segment depending on complexity.

8.2 Movement and Exploration

- Locations have exits to adjacent spaces with traversal costs
- Some exits are locked by access condition (rank, relationship, time of day, physical key)
- Moving through significant locations generates narration conditioned on time, weather, player state, and world state
- Visiting a location multiple times does not generate identical narration
- Travel between clusters costs meaningful time

8.3 The Conversation Intent Grammar

Conversation is not a menu. The player expresses intent, topic, and tone. The engine evaluates conditions and the LLM narrates the result.

Dimension	Options
Act	ask / tell / request / flatter / provoke / deflect / lie / perform / remain silent / leave

Topic	person / place / event / rumour / favour / object / self / magic / obligation
Tone	warm / careful / casual / bold / manipulative / angry / joking / evasive
Constraint	What the player actually knows (engine-verified before narration)

The engine checks: Does the player know this topic? What is the NPC's current attitude? What is the relationship level? What are the NPC's taboo topics and exit conditions? The LLM then narrates a response consistent with those constraints.

8.4 Money and Economy

- Currency: talents, jots, drabs (confirmed canonical denominations)
- Use confirmed canonical prices where the text provides them
- Tracked as a real variable with persistent consequences
- Regular expenses: lodging, food, tuition, tools, instrument maintenance
- Money pressure is real in the early University era — this is not optional flavour

8.5 Reputation System

Reputation is tracked along multiple independent axes. The player never sees raw numbers. Reputation surfaces descriptively.

Axis	Descriptive States (Internal → Surface)
Academic standing	E'lir → Re'lar → El'the (public ranks) plus individual master attitudes
Student social reputation	Mocked / Ignored / Noticed / Liked / Respected / Feared
Masters' individual attitudes	Separate per master: Tolerant / Neutral / Watchful / Hostile / Impressed
Performance reputation	Unknown / Heard of / Admired / Sought out / Pipist equivalent
Ruh identity disclosure	Concealed / Suspected / Known — each state has different social consequences
Individual relationships	Per-NPC trust and tension, surfaced through dialogue and NPC behaviour

Reputation changes have realistic lag. Word travels at realistic speed. Bad reputation in one domain does not automatically affect others.

8.6 Academic Rank and Tuition

- Rank advancement: Arcanum entry → E'lir → Re'lar → El'the
- Each advancement has specific requirements (examination before masters, canon-confirmed)
- Missing classes, antagonising masters, and failures have consequences on rank and tuition amount

- Access to restricted areas gated by rank
- Tuition amount varies — masters can raise or lower it; the exam scene is a canon-fixed event

8.7 Music and Performance

- Lute playing is a skill and a world-building element, not a mini-game
- Performance quality is affected by instrument condition, player emotional state, practice level, and audience
- The Eolian has specific social and reputational stakes — performing here matters
- Music can open social doors and provide income
- The connection between music and Kvothe's sympathy / naming must be hinted at carefully, not over-explained

8.8 Magic — Sympathy

Sympathy adjudication belongs to the engine. The LLM narrates the outcome, but cannot invent new sympathy rules.

Engine Check	What the Engine Verifies
Binding validity	Is the sympathetic link plausible given the materials and the player's training?
Materials present	Does the player have or have access to the linking materials?
Alar strength	What is the player's split-attention capacity at this moment?
Thermodynamic cost	What is the body heat cost? Is the player already cold, injured, or exhausted?
Risk level	What are the failure states? Slip, bleed-through, injury, unconsciousness?

Failure states are real and painful. Sympathy cannot be used reliably in high emotional distress without training to match. The LLM narrates outcome, failure, and consequence within engine-verified parameters.

8.9 Magic — Naming

> *Naming is not a player-facing system. It is a rare event state, a script-assisted threshold moment, tightly gated, and heavily canon-checked. Remove it from ordinary mechanical consideration entirely.*

- Available only in specific states: clarity, exhaustion-break, extreme crisis, deep focus — not on demand
- Cannot be turned on like an ability
- Early University era: barely glimpsed, poorly understood

- What Kvothe can name is strictly limited to what canon shows at that exact point in the timeline
- The wind is his first real naming — and even that is fragile and unrepeatable on demand
- The engine gates naming entirely; the LLM does not initiate or unlock naming moments

8.10 Health, Injury, Fatigue, and Body State

- Injuries persist until treated; Medica access matters
- Fatigue affects sympathy alar quality and conversation effectiveness
- Hunger affects everything; not eating is a real consequence
- Sleep deprivation (which Kvothe canonically endures) has measurable cognitive cost
- Cold increases thermodynamic sympathy cost; do not use sympathy when already cold or injured without accepting the risk

8.11 NPC Schedules and the Living World

The 'living world' claim requires real implementation. Without NPC schedules and location states, it remains aspirational.

System	What It Does
NPC schedules by daypart	Each major NPC has a known location per daypart; they are findable or not findable based on this
Location operating hours	Archives closes, Anker's opens, the Eolian runs evenings only
Class timetable	Specific classes at specific dayparts; missing them has consequences
Tuition countdown	Term deadline approaching; tracked persistently
Crowd level by daypart	Affects observation risk, conversation privacy, eavesdropping probability
Rumour spread over time	Rumours propagate at realistic rates; NPC knowledge updates accordingly
NPC knowledge propagation	What NPCs know about the player's actions updates based on what they could plausibly have learned

8.12 Player State — Additional Fields

Beyond location, money, and health, the following must be tracked:

- Obligations: tuition due, promised favours, assignment deadlines
- Cover stories and active lies: what the player has claimed and to whom
- Body heat available: sympathy cost reserve
- Instrument condition: affects performance quality
- Clothing state: affects social perception in formal or Eolian settings
- Sleep debt: accumulated cognitive cost

- Social embarrassment flags: public failures that have become known

8.13 World State — Additional Fields

Field	Purpose
term_week	Current week of the academic term; gates events and deadlines
campus_busyness	High / Normal / Quiet — affects crowd, observation risk, NPC availability
active_gossip_graph	What is currently being talked about and by whom
NPC awareness matrix	Which NPCs know what about the player's recent actions
rumour_pool	Active rumours in circulation with truth_status and source_reliability

SECTION 9 — NARRATIVE STRUCTURE

9. Narrative Structure

9.1 Sandbox vs Guided Balance

The game is simulation-forward with narrative anchors, not a linear story with the illusion of choice.

The simulation layer runs constantly: time passes, NPCs move through their days, tuition is due, weather changes, rumours circulate. The player can follow any thread or none.

The narrative anchor layer provides: canon-fixed events that will occur regardless of player action, and character-driven goals the player develops through play.

9.2 Elastic Canon Zones vs High-Risk Canon Zones

Elastic Canon Zones

Stretches where major canon outcomes are fixed but daily detail is fully open. Player agency is meaningful and no contradiction risk is likely. The MVP should live almost entirely here.

- Ordinary days at the University between canon peaks
- Fishery work sessions
- Evenings at Anker's
- Visits to Imre not tied to major canon events
- Most social manoeuvring with Sim, Wil, and minor NPCs

High-Risk Canon Zones

> *High-Risk Canon Zones require special approval before implementation. Do not approach these casually.*

- The tuition examination scene — canon-fixed in structure
- The Archives ban — canon-fixed; player cannot prevent it
- Major Denna interactions — patron must never be hinted at
- Any scene involving the Chandrian in present-day action
- First naming moments — must be fragile, unrepeatable, not player-triggered
- Felurian — out of scope
- Frame-story revelation beats — out of scope

9.3 Canon-Fixed Events — Handling Philosophy

Some events in the books are fixed. They happened. In a game set during those eras, they will happen. The question is not whether, but how the player experiences them.

- What does the player notice before, during, and after?
- What do they attempt to influence around the edges?
- What secondary consequences follow from how they positioned themselves?
- How do they feel, and what do they do immediately after?

The game does not prevent the whipping, does not prevent the Archives ban, does not let the player avoid tuition. But the player can affect the texture of how events unfold, what they learn from them, and what they do next.

9.4 Handling Iconic Scenes

- Do not reproduce the book's prose
- Allow the player to approach the scene from their own angle
- The emotional core of the scene must be intact
- Do not let the player trivially sidestep what the scene demands of the character
- Do not over-dramatise scenes the books treat quietly

9.5 Slow Daily Life vs Dramatic Events

Both should feel valid. A turn spent watching Auri leave small gifts in unexpected places should feel as real and meaningful as a sympathy duel. The game never signals that slow turns are wasted turns.

SECTION 10 — INFORMATION ARCHITECTURE

10. Information Architecture

This is a platform-agnostic conceptual schema. It defines what data exists and what fields matter. Final implementation format (JSON, SQLite, flat files) is a Phase 2 decision.

10.1 Location

```
id                      string (unique)
name                    string
cluster_id              string
era_availability        string[]
description_base        string (tone-reviewed)
description_variants    object { time_of_day, weather, player_state,
visit_count, world_flags }
hours_open              object { daypart: bool }
traversal_cost          object { target_id: { time_min, fatigue_cost } }
exits                   array { direction, target_id, access_condition }
ambient_tags            object { sound, smell, crowd_by_daypart }
social_hazard_flags     string[]
npcs_present            array { npc_id, conditions, schedule }
objects_present         array { object_id, conditions }
scene_templates         object { first_visit, repeat_visit, time_variants }
repeat_visit_counter    integer
off_limits_visible      string (description of what can be seen but not
reached)
canon_source            object { book, chapter, note }
tier                    integer (1|2|3)
```

10.2 Character (NPC)

```
id                          string
name                        string
aliases                     string[]
era_availability            string[]
location_default            object { era: location_id }
schedule_by_daypart         object { daypart: location_id }
speech_style_notes          string
temperament_notes           string
social_status               object { era: string }
daily_routine               string
```

```
known_capabilities         array { capability, canon_source }
known_limitations          array { limitation, canon_source }
relationships              array { npc_id, nature, public_knowledge,
private_knowledge }
taboo_topics               string[]
what_they_hide             string (from canon implication only, never
invention)
conversation_stance        object { relationship_level: string }
conversation_exit_triggers string[]
lies_they_tell             string
noticing_priorities        string
tone_shift_triggers        string[]
what_is_publicly_known     string
what_is_privately_known    string
what_is_unknown_in_canon   string (must not be invented)
authority_over_player      string
canon_source               object { book, chapter, note }
tier                       integer (1|2|3)
```

10.3 Rumour

```
id                  string
text                string (as heard in-world)
truth_status        enum { true, false, partially_true, unknown }
source_reliability  enum { reliable, unreliable, unknown }
spread_scope        enum { local, campus, city, wide }
decay_rate          string (how quickly this stops being actively told)
contradiction_group string (ID of any contradicting rumours)
related_mystery     string (mystery ID if applicable)
available_from_era  string
```

10.4 Event

```
id                  string
name                string
era                 string
is_canon_fixed      boolean
trigger_condition   string
visibility          enum { public, private, witnessed }
description         string
can_player_miss_it  boolean
blockers            string[] (what prevents trigger)
world_state_changes array { field, change }
aftermath_states    array { condition, consequence }
```

```
player_agency_notes string
canon_source        object { book, chapter, note }
```

10.5 Player State

```
character_id            string
era                     string
location_id             string
daypart                 string
term_week               integer
inventory               string[]
money                   object { talents, jots, drabs }
health                  object { description, injuries[] }
fatigue_level           integer (1-5)
hunger_level            integer (1-5)
sleep_debt              integer
body_heat_reserve       integer (sympathy cost reserve)
instrument_condition    enum { excellent, good, worn, damaged, broken }
clothing_state          enum { good, presentable, worn, threadbare }
academic_rank           enum { E'lir, Re'lar, El'the }
sympathy_skill          integer
sygaldry_skill          integer
known_bindings          string[]
reputation              object { academic, student_social, masters{},
eolian, ruh_disclosed }
individual_relations    object { npc_id: { trust, tension, history[] } }
knowledge_flags         string[]
obligations             array { type, deadline, to_whom }
cover_stories           array { claim, told_to[], still_active }
active_lies             array { lie, told_to[], at_risk }
debts                   array { to, amount_or_nature, due }
promises_made           array { to, nature, fulfilled }
social_embarrassment    string[]
world_state_flags       string[]
```

10.6 World State

```
era                     string
active_events           string[]
completed_events        string[]
term_week               integer
season                  enum { early_autumn, late_autumn, winter, spring,
summer }
weather_current         string
```

```
campus_busyness         enum { quiet, normal, busy, festival }
npc_states              object { npc_id: { location, mood, player_knowledge,
attitude } }
location_states         object { location_id: { locked, special_conditions }
}
rumour_pool             string[] (active rumour IDs)
active_gossip_graph     object { topic: npc_ids_discussing[] }
npc_awareness_matrix    object { npc_id: player_action_ids_known[] }
```

10.7 Canon Source Reference

```
element_id    string
element_type  string
claim         string
book          enum { NotW, WMF, SRST }
chapter_page  string
tier          integer (1|2|3)
reviewer      string
notes         string
```

SECTION 11 — CONTENT PIPELINE

11. Content Pipeline

11.1 Order of Content Building

13. Lore Register — before any content is written
14. World schema — before any locations are built
15. Cluster design documents — before any room descriptions are written
16. Character documents — before any dialogue rules are written
17. Systems in minimal working form
18. One complete test arc: wake, decide, attend, work, cross to Imre, return

11.2 The Cluster-First Approach

Do not write individual room descriptions in isolation. Build clusters as coherent wholes.

Cluster	Build in One Pass
Anker's cluster	Room, corridor, common room, back area. Internal coherence first.
University campus cluster	Courtyard, Mains, adjacent spaces. Geographic coherence first.
Archives cluster	Entrance, Tomes, restricted access threshold. Access rules first.
Fishery cluster	Outer workspace, Kilvin's area, materials storage. Work flow first.
Eolian cluster	Street approach, door, floor, stage threshold. Social stakes first.

11.3 Location Design Document (Required Before Prose)

Before writing a single description, each location gets a design document answering:

- What is this place for? (Social function, not just physical)
- Who uses it, when, and why?
- What tensions exist here regularly?
- What does it smell like, sound like, feel like in different conditions?
- What is always true of it? What changes by time and season?
- What access rules apply?
- How does it connect to adjacent spaces geographically?

11.4 Content Budget Per Cluster

Element	Budget
Spaces per cluster	8–15
Major NPCs per cluster	2–4
Ambient NPC loops	3 (non-interactive background presence)
Rumours in circulation	3 active at any time
Repeat-visit variants per key space	At minimum 2 (time of day)
Weather variants per key space	At minimum 1
Social hazard flags	1 per cluster
Canon anchor events	1 per cluster
Review passes	1 canon review + 1 tone review before shipping

11.5 NPC Writing Consistency

Before writing any dialogue rule, each NPC gets a Character Voice Document including:

- Five sample sentences in their voice (from canonical dialogue where possible)
- Five things they would never say
- Taboo topics — what makes them close off
- What they want from interactions with the player at this point in the story
- How they treat the player at different relationship levels

11.6 The Tone Test

Before shipping any narration, scene, or dialogue, run this checklist:

- Does this scene earn its emotional moment through accumulated detail?
- Is there something materially specific here — a price, a smell, a worn object?
- Does this character's dialogue sound like themselves or like a convenient plot device?
- Is there something unknown or unresolvable in this scene that adds texture?
- Would a reader who loves the books feel recognised here?
- Does any sentence feel like it was written to sound literary rather than to be true?

11.7 Canon Drift Audit Schedule

- End of each content phase: full audit pass
- Audit questions: Does every element have a citation? Has any character started behaving differently under gameplay pressure? Have any mysteries been edged toward

resolution? Has any Tier 3 inference started being treated as Tier 1? Does the magic system still have real costs?

- Regression testing: Keep transcript-based playtests. When systems change, replay the same scenario and check for lore drift, state drift, and character voice drift.

SECTION 12 — MVP DEFINITION

12. MVP Definition

12.1 The True Vertical Slice

> *Title: University Vertical Slice — "One Term Morning"*

Element	Specification
Player character	Kvothe only
Era	Early University — first or second term
Playable time span	1–2 in-game days
Total locations	11 (as specified in Section 5.2)
Fully modelled NPCs	3 — Simmon, Wilem, Kilvin
Semi-modelled NPCs	2 — Anker, plus one of Ambrose or Denna
Canon-fixed events	Exactly 1
Magic system	Sympathy basics only — no naming as a player system
Other eras	None
Other playable characters	None
Underthing	Out of scope
Chandrian play	Out of scope
Auri	At most one gated optional encounter, or none

12.2 MVP Success Condition

A player should be able to:

19. Wake in their room and decide whether to spend money on breakfast or save it for tuition
20. Attend or consciously miss something that matters
21. Work at Anker's or attempt Fishery work under Kilvin
22. Navigate to Imre and the Eolian on foot
23. Make one socially consequential choice whose effects persist
24. Attempt one sympathy action with real cost and real risk
25. Feel, without being told, the specific weight of being Kvothe at the start of his University years

12.3 Why This MVP and Not Others

Alternative	Why Not MVP
Waystone Inn	Three characters, one location. Excellent for depth but too narrow to prove the world. Better as later addition.
Tarbean	Rich but dark and socially narrow. Fewer confirmed specific locations than University. Strong Phase 2 candidate.
Troupe era	Requires building an environment specifically to make its destruction land. Phase 3 at earliest.
Multiple eras at once	Multiplies scope, canon risk, and NPC complexity before any single era is proven. Indefensible at MVP.

SECTION 13 — PHASE PLAN

13. Phase Plan

Phase 1 — Canon Bible and Lore Extraction

Field	Content
Objective	Build the authoritative lore database before any content is created.
Duration estimate	3–5 weeks
Outputs	Complete Lore Register with all Tier 1–3 facts from all three books. Timeline document. Character documents for all major canon characters. Location inventory. Magic system rules. Currency and economy document. Social structure document. Canon Red List. Contradiction Register.
Risks	Fanon contamination if using wikis as primary source. Underestimating scope.
Mitigation	All entries cite specific book passages. Wikis used as finding aids only. Budget generously — all subsequent work depends on this phase.
Dependencies	Access to all three published books in searchable form.
Definition of done	Every major element intended for the MVP has a citation in the Lore Register. No uncited elements exist in any content document. Canon Red List formally adopted.

Phase 2 — World Model and Schema

Field	Content
Objective	Define the complete structural framework before content is written.
Duration estimate	2–3 weeks
Outputs	Final data schema for all entity types. University cluster map with confirmed rooms, exits, and access rules. Imre cluster map. NPC roster with complete character documents. Dialogue intent grammar specification. Sympathy adjudication rules document. Academic rank and tuition system specification.
Risks	Over-engineering schema before knowing what the system needs.
Mitigation	Build schema iteratively. Minimum viable fields first. Expand only when actual content needs reveal gaps.
Dependencies	Phase 1 complete.

Definition of done	A developer can build one complete test location and one complete test NPC without inventing anything not in the schema.

Phase 3 — MVP Location and Core Systems

Field	Content
Objective	Build the University vertical slice to a playable state with core mechanics functioning.
Duration estimate	6–8 weeks
Outputs	All 11 MVP locations navigable and described. Movement, time passage, and basic inventory working. Money, hunger, and fatigue system working. Sympathy system in basic playable form. Academic rank and tuition system working. NPC schedules implemented. One canon-fixed event scripted.
Risks	Rooms feel like isolated set pieces rather than a living campus. Sympathy system becomes gamey under pressure. Tone drifts toward generic fantasy.
Mitigation	Build in clusters. Run tone review with book-familiar readers. Sympathy always asks 'what does this cost?' Engine owns adjudication.
Dependencies	Phase 2 complete.
Definition of done	A player can spend one full in-game day at the University, attend class, work in the Fishery, eat at Anker's, cross to Imre, and return — with all practical consequences tracked correctly.

Phase 4 — NPC and Dialogue Systems

Field	Content
Objective	Make canon NPCs feel genuinely themselves.
Duration estimate	4–6 weeks
Outputs	Simmon, Wilem, Kilvin fully dialogue-enabled with correct voice. Conversation intent grammar implemented. NPC knowledge states updating from world events. Relationship tracking working. Bespoke rule packs for Denna and Ambrose (semi-modelled).
Risks	NPCs become quest-givers. Elodin becomes too explicable. Denna becomes a romance reward.
Mitigation	Each NPC has a refusal list. Elodin must always leave more questions. Denna must never be reliably available. Regular tone review.
Dependencies	Phase 3 complete.

Definition of done	A reader of the books can have a conversation with Simmon and find it believable; a conversation with Kilvin and hear his voice; a conversation with Elodin (if present) and feel appropriately uncertain.

Phase 5 — Reputation and Consequence Layer

Field	Content
Objective	Make the world feel like it remembers what the player does.
Duration estimate	3–4 weeks
Outputs	Full reputation system wired across all axes. Consequence propagation working. World state updating correctly. Debt and promise tracking. NPC awareness matrix functioning.
Risks	Consequences feel arbitrary or punitive. Reputation updates too fast (gamey) or too slow (nothing seems to matter).
Mitigation	Test each consequence: 'Would this realistically happen, at this speed, in this social environment?' Slow is usually more correct than fast.
Dependencies	Phase 4 complete.
Definition of done	A player who antagonises Ambrose early feels effects 20 turns later in ways that feel inevitable, not mechanical. A player who performs well at the Eolian notices doors opening gradually.

Phase 6 — Expansion to More Eras and Regions

Field	Content
Objective	Build Tarbean, the frame era, and the troupe era as distinct playable experiences.
Duration estimate	10–16 weeks across sub-phases
Outputs	Tarbean with Skarpi, specific districts, poverty mechanics. Frame era Waystone Inn with Bast, Chronicler, and correct weight. Troupe era wagons and roads with the approach of the massacre.
Risks	The massacre becomes exploitable or trivialised. Frame era loses its weight. Tarbean poverty becomes tourism.
Mitigation	Each era has its own tone document. The massacre is a canon-fixed catastrophe — the player experiences it, cannot prevent it. Frame era dialogue is sparse and deliberate.
Dependencies	Phases 1–5 complete and stable.
Definition of done	Each era supports at least 2 hours of meaningful play with no canon drift, correct consequences, and distinct tone.

SECTION 14 — RISK ANALYSIS

14. Risk Analysis

Risk	Severity	Probability	Mitigation
Lore contradiction	Critical	Medium	Lore Register with citations as foundation; canon audit at end of every phase
Scope explosion	High	High	Hard rule: nothing new until current phase is complete and verified; MVP ceiling is enforced
Bland prose	High	Medium	Tone review with book-familiar readers; no narration written without Location Design Document
Weak NPC voices	High	High	Character Voice Documents; refusal lists; separate review pass per major NPC
Generic fantasy drift	High	Medium	Regular canon audit; magic system has explicit 'no' list; consequences are social, not just physical
Broken timeline logic	High	Low (with discipline)	Timeline model is separate per era; player state resets cleanly between eras
Mystery resolved cheaply	Critical	Low (with discipline)	Canon Red List formally adopted; all mysteries flagged 'never resolve in game'
Over-modelling too soon	Medium	High	Schema-minimal start; expand only when actual content requires it
Auri handled incorrectly	High	Medium	Auri has separate canon document; all Auri content reviewed against SRST specifically
Felurian becomes shallow	High	Low (out of scope)	Felurian is out of scope until Phase 6+; requires dedicated review when approached
Frame era loses weight	High	Medium	Kote has a silence requirement — minimum proportion of turns where he says little or nothing
Fanon contamination	Medium	Medium	All facts traced to text; wikis as finding aids only; no uncited claims
LLM inventing lore	Critical	High (without controls)	Engine owns all state, facts, and rule adjudication; LLM only narrates within engine-verified context
Mode C legal exposure	High	Low (if careful)	Decide mode early; no verbatim text reproduction; clear fan-work attribution

SECTION 15 — VALIDATION AND REVIEW

15. Validation and Review

15.1 Canon Validation

Every shipped asset must pass all four checks before it leaves review:

- Cited — source book and chapter recorded
- Tiered — confidence tier (1, 2, or 3) assigned
- Reviewed — a second reader has checked for canon accuracy
- Approved — the asset has been cleared for inclusion

15.2 Tone Validation

Each scene must pass all of the following:

- No modern phrasing
- No generic fantasy exposition
- No over-lyrical purple prose
- No character flattening
- No cheap mystery solving
- The emotional weight is earned, not announced

15.3 Simulation Validation

Test questions to run at the end of each phase:

- Can the player spend a full day without contradiction?
- Do repeated visits to locations change believably?
- Do missed obligations matter later?
- Does money pressure meaningfully shape choices?
- Does social fallout persist across turns?
- Can the player fail quietly, not just dramatically?
- Do NPC schedules hold up — are characters findable when they should be and absent when they should be?

15.4 Regression Testing

Keep transcript-based playtests. After any significant system change, replay the same scenario and check for:

- Lore drift — anything that was correct before and is now wrong
- State drift — persistent state being lost or corrupted
- Character voice drift — NPC responses that no longer sound like themselves
- Consequence drift — effects of earlier actions no longer propagating correctly

SECTION 16 — TOOLING RECOMMENDATION

16. Tooling Recommendation

16.1 Option Comparison

Option	Summary and Verdict
A — Pure interactive fiction engine (Inform 7, Twine, Ink)	Well-established for the genre. Ink is the strongest candidate. But static content only — everything must be pre-written. Does not scale to the density this project requires. Appropriate for a small one-location prototype only.
B — Custom app with structured data	Full control over schema and state. Scales well if structured properly. Significant engineering work. All prose still pre-written. Best for a developer-led project with a stable technical team.
C — LLM-assisted dynamic narration with canon database	Dramatically reduces pre-written content burden. Handles variation naturally. Requires very careful prompt architecture. LLM will occasionally hallucinate facts — requires a canon-checking layer. Inconsistency harder to guarantee across sessions.
D — Hybrid structured engine + LLM narration layer	Engine controls world state, movement, consequences, and canon facts. LLM only writes narration and conversational texture, within strict engine-verified boundaries. Most complex architecture, but most scalable and most faithful to the design pillars. RECOMMENDED.

16.2 Recommended Architecture

```
Canon Database (JSON or SQLite)
   │
   ▼
World State Engine (TypeScript or Python)
   │  — owns state, legality, travel, economy, canon flags
   │  — adjudicates sympathy, access rules, reputation changes
   │  — evaluates conversation conditions
   ▼
LLM Narration Layer (constrained system prompt)
   │  — receives: current location, world state, player state, NPC state
   │  — receives: verified canon facts only — never raw lore questions
   │  — generates: narration and dialogue within engine-verified constraints
   │  — cannot invent lore, cannot resolve mysteries, cannot override engine
   ▼
Player-facing interface (web or terminal)
```

The LLM's system prompt is the canon philosophy document — tone rules, character rules, mystery rules — plus the current structured world state and player state as verified data. The LLM cannot invent lore because the engine only passes it confirmed facts.

16.3 The Critical Boundary

> *The engine decides what is true. The LLM decides how to say it. This boundary must be explicit in the architecture and enforced in every system interaction. Violations of this boundary are the primary failure mode for the hybrid approach.*

SECTION 17 — FINAL RECOMMENDATION

17. Final Recommendation

17.1 Recommended Project Shape

A hybrid structured-engine and LLM narration system, canon-database-first, built in phases, beginning with a tightly scoped University vertical slice.

The project is not a game in the conventional sense. It is a canon-faithful interactive world where the primary experience is inhabiting the books' setting with consequence and texture. Think of it as somewhere between 80 Days and Pentiment in spirit — literary, consequence-driven, unhurried, specific.

17.2 What to Keep From v1

- The canon-first philosophy
- The mystery-preservation philosophy
- The social and material realism commitment
- The hybrid structured-engine direction
- The University-first instinct

17.3 What Changes From v1

- Scope is explicitly smaller — the MVP is a true vertical slice, not a small game
- The rights/release decision is a hard gate before any build begins
- The data model is operational, not just conceptual
- Testing has a dedicated section and enforced workflow
- The LLM-owns-truth failure mode is explicitly named and architecturally prevented
- Dangerous content categories are explicitly deferred or flagged, not just listed as 'later'
- The frame-era University state is no longer asserted as 'ruins' — it is correctly marked as unknown

17.4 The 10 Most Important Decisions — In Order

26. **1. Is this private, public non-commercial, or intended for release?** This is Gate 0. Nothing else proceeds without this answer.
27. **2. Is the MVP strictly Kvothe-only?** Yes. Confirm this explicitly before Phase 1 begins.
28. **3. Which exact 11 locations are in the first slice?** Use Section 5.2 as the starting point. Confirm before Phase 2.

29. **4. Which 3 NPCs are fully modelled first?** Simmon, Wilem, Kilvin. Confirm this sequence.
30. **5. What is the turn and time model?** Scene-based with daypart tracking as specified in Section 8.1. Confirm before any schedule is built.
31. **6. What is the player interface?** Parser, hybrid command, or guided free-text? Each has different implications for conversation design.
32. **7. Does the engine own state and rule adjudication, not the LLM?** This must be a formal architectural decision, not just an intention.
33. **8. What is the canon citation workflow?** Who maintains the Lore Register? What tool or format is used? What is the review process?
34. **9. What is the tone review workflow?** Who reads new content, what are they checking for, and who has authority to reject?
35. **10. What exact condition marks the MVP complete?** Use the seven-point success condition in Section 12.2. The MVP is done when a player can do all seven things in a single session.

This document is a living planning artefact.

Revisit scope definition and risk register at the end of each phase.

The canon bible is the foundation. Do not shortcut it.